

What's your personality?

What kind of person are you—a party animal or a quiet bookworm? Are you friendly and good-natured or argumentative and bad-tempered? Everyone has a unique personality. Your personality is molded by your genes and your upbringing, and it has a big influence on your life and the career you might choose.

FIVE DIMENSIONS

When we get to know someone, we instinctively form our own personal opinion about their personality. Psychologists try to measure personality in a more scientific way. They focus on five or more different “dimensions” of personality, such as extroversion and agreeableness, each of which is measured separately by answering questions. You can measure the five dimensions of your own personality by taking the quiz on page 236.

FAST FACTS

- The male sex hormone testosterone affects personality, making boys more competitive and aggressive than girls.
- Men have slightly bigger brains than women, but the average IQ of men and women is the same.
- Some people think you can use a person's handwriting to study their personality, but there's no scientific evidence that this works.



◀ **CONSCIENTIOUSNESS** *A person with a high score for conscientiousness is reliable, hardworking, and punctual (on time). Conscientious people strive to do their best and are usually neat and tidy, though they can be a little fussy.*

▶ **EXTROVERSION** *Extroverts thrive best in the company of others and are confident and talkative. Introverts are the opposite and tend to be shy and wary of strangers.*



◀ **NEUROTICISM** *People with a high score for neuroticism get upset, worried, or excited more easily than other people. They might be regarded as sensitive or high-strung. The opposite is someone who's always calm, even in stressful situations.*



▶ **AGREEABLENESS** *This is a measure of how easy you are to get along with. If you score highly, people find you cooperative and good-natured. If you have a low score, you might be argumentative. People tend to become more agreeable as they get older.*



◀ **OPENNESS** *If you're very open, you like new experiences and change. You make decisions on the spur of the moment rather than following plans, and you tend to dip into things rather than immersing yourself in one hobby.*

